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**UNITED NATIONS SECURITY COUNCIL
BACKGROUND GUIDE**

Letter from the Executive Board

Greetings Delegates,

The Executive Board of the UNSC welcomes you to BITSMUN. The EB hopes that you all are in good health and ready for the committee. We aim to make this as comfortable an experience for you as possible. Please do not refrain from sharing your doubts with us. As senseless as they might seem to you, trust us, even we had them when we were beginners. Your confidence will grow gradually as you get familiar with your surroundings in the committee. Come with an open mind, and most importantly come with a willingness to try. It is our personal experience that public speaking is really compelling. Give yourself that first chance and it will grow on you.

This guide has been created to serve as a starting point for your research and to give you a brief overview of the subject matter. We would highly encourage you to research well. Know that the background guide is only the first step of your research and only when you are well versed in the nuance of the topic will you be able to extract the most out of the event. We would also highly recommend you to be attentive and coordinate with your fellow committee members in order to come up with creative and effective solutions. Furthermore, it is important to note that this committee can only be dealt with if you have the willingness to research extensively and translate research into ideas.

We wish you all the best and hope that we can make this a fruitful experience for you. The Executive Board will always be there to help you with any or all confusion that you might face during the course of the committee, please feel free to reach out to us without any hesitation. Best of luck with your preparation!

Regards,

BITSMUN 2025 International Press Committee Background Guide: Mastering the Fourth Estate

This comprehensive guide equips press committee participants with essential knowledge, strategies, and creative approaches needed to produce outstanding coverage at BITSMUN 2025. By combining journalistic excellence with diplomatic understanding, you will serve as the critical link between committee proceedings and the broader audience.

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Background of the Agenda

"The United Nations Security Council is the custodian of global peace, but its strength lies not in its vetoes, but in its unity."

The conflict in Yemen, which has persisted for nearly a decade, has resulted in one of the world's most severe humanitarian crises. Rooted in political instability following the 2011 Arab Spring protests, the conflict escalated in 2014 when the Houthi rebel movement seized the capital, Sanaa, leading to a Saudi-led military intervention in 2015. The war has since evolved into a complex geopolitical struggle, involving regional and international actors, exacerbating civilian suffering, and destabilizing the broader Middle East.

The Houthis, officially known as Ansar Allah, are a Zaidi Shia movement that has fought against the Yemeni government and its allies for years. With significant military and logistical support from Iran, the Houthis have expanded their operations beyond Yemen's borders, targeting Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, and, more recently, international maritime routes.

Since late 2023, the Houthis have intensified their attacks on commercial and military vessels in the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden. These assaults, allegedly in response to Western and Israeli actions in the region, have disrupted global trade and heightened tensions between regional and global powers. The attacks have primarily targeted ships associated with Israel, the U.S., and its allies, posing a direct threat to international maritime security.

Fighting between Houthi rebels and the Saudi coalition that backs Yemen's internationally recognized government has largely subsided, but Houthis have repeatedly attacked ships transiting the Red Sea in response to Israel's war on Hamas. Dialogue between the Houthis and Saudi Arabia, along with Iranian-Saudi normalization, has provided hope for a negotiated solution. However, talks have yielded little progress and have been punctuated by violence. The Southern Transitional Council (STC) has also renewed calls for an independent southern Yemeni state, complicating peace prospects, and al-Qaeda in the Arabian Peninsula (AQAP) attacks have surged. Meanwhile, the humanitarian crisis has not improved; 21.6 million people need aid, including 11 million children, and more than 4.5 million are displaced.

Breakdown of the Agenda

Yemen's civil war began in 2014 when Houthi insurgency—Shiite rebels with links to Iran and a history of rising up against the Sunni government—took control of Yemen's capital and largest city, Sanaa, demanding lower fuel prices and a new government. Following failed negotiations, the rebels seized the presidential palace in January 2015, leading President Abd Rabbu Mansour Hadi and his government to resign. Beginning in March 2015, a coalition of Gulf states led by Saudi Arabia launched a campaign of economic isolation and air strikes against the Houthi insurgents, with U.S. logistical and intelligence support.

In February 2015, after escaping from Sanaa, Hadi rescinded his resignation, complicating the UN-supported transitional council formed to govern from the southern port city of Aden. However, a Houthi advance forced Hadi to flee Aden for exile in Saudi Arabia. While he attempted to return to Aden later that year, he ultimately ruled as president in exile.

The intervention of regional powers in Yemen's conflict, including Iran and Gulf states led by Saudi Arabia, also drew the country into a regional proxy struggle along the broader Sunni-Shia divide. In June 2015, Saudi Arabia implemented a naval blockade to prevent Iran from supplying the Houthis. In response, Iran dispatched a naval convoy, raising the risk of military escalation between the two countries. The militarization of Yemen's waters also drew the attention of the U.S. Navy, which has continued to seize Yemen-bound Iranian weapons. The blockade has been at the center of the humanitarian crisis throughout the conflict. Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates have also led an unrelenting air campaign, with their coalition carrying out over twenty-five thousand air strikes. These strikes have caused over nineteen thousand civilian casualties, and from 2021 to 2022 the Houthis responded with a spate of drone attacks on Saudi Arabia and the UAE.

The conflict has taken a heavy toll on Yemeni civilians, making Yemen the world's worst humanitarian crisis. The UN estimates that 60 percent of the estimated 377,000 deaths in Yemen between 2015 and the beginning of 2022 were the result of indirect causes like food insecurity and lack of accessible health services. Two-thirds of the population, or 21.6 million Yemenis, remain in dire need of assistance. Five million are at risk of famine, and a cholera outbreak has affected over one million people. All sides of the conflict are reported to have violated human rights and international humanitarian law.

Recent Developments and Escalation of Houthi Maritime Attacks

The Red Sea and the Bab el-Mandeb Strait are among the most strategically significant waterways in global trade. The Bab el-Mandeb, meaning "Gate of Tears," is a narrow passage (approximately 29 km wide) between Yemen on the Arabian Peninsula and Djibouti and Eritrea on the African coast. It serves as a critical choke point for global commerce, linking the Indian Ocean to the Mediterranean Sea via the Suez Canal.

Around 10% of the world's trade flows through this route, including vital shipments of oil, liquefied natural gas (LNG), and consumer goods. The Suez Canal, through which the Red Sea leads into the Mediterranean, is a vital artery for trade between Asia, the Middle East, Europe, and North America. Major energy exporters, including Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Iraq, use this route for oil exports to Europe and the U.S.

Any disruption in the Bab el-Mandeb Strait affects global shipping, increases transit costs, and heightens geopolitical tensions. Past disruptions, such as the 2021 Ever Given blockage in the Suez Canal, demonstrated how even a temporary disruption could lead to global supply chain crises. Global naval powers, including the U.S., UK, France, and China, maintain a military presence in the region to secure shipping lanes.

In late 2023 and early 2024, the Iran-backed Houthi rebels escalated their attacks on commercial and military vessels in the Red Sea, citing retaliation for the Israel-Gaza war and claiming to target Israeli-linked shipping. However, the attacks have affected a broad range of international vessels, impacting global trade.

The Houthis have fired ballistic missiles and drones at vessels they suspect of links to Israel, the U.S., or allied countries. The Houthis are believed to be using Iranian-supplied ASBMs with improvised guidance systems, increasing their ability to strike moving naval targets. These missiles pose a significant challenge for commercial and military vessels operating in the region. Reports indicate that the Houthis have deployed sea mines, posing a severe threat to commercial shipping and naval operations. In November 2023, the Galaxy Leader, a cargo ship linked to Israeli owners, was hijacked by Houthi forces. Houthi officials threatened further attacks against commercial vessels deemed to be aiding Israel.

Iran's Role and Allegations of Arms Shipments to the Houthis

Iran has been accused of providing extensive military and logistical support to the Houthi rebels, significantly influencing the conflict in Yemen. Multiple intelligence reports and UN investigations suggest that Iran has supplied the Houthis with advanced weaponry, including ballistic missiles, drones, and naval mines, which have been used in both land-based conflicts and maritime attacks in the Red Sea. The United Nations Panel of Experts on Yemen has repeatedly cited evidence of Iranian-made weapons found in Houthi-controlled territories, despite a UN arms embargo on Yemen under UNSC Resolution 2216 (2015). These shipments often reach the Houthis through smuggling routes via the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea, using networks of small boats and commercial vessels to evade detection.

Iran's involvement is often viewed as part of its broader proxy strategy in the Middle East, aimed at countering Saudi Arabia's influence in the region. Tehran denies direct military involvement but openly supports the Houthis politically and ideologically, framing their actions as part of the "Axis of Resistance" against Western and Gulf intervention. The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) and its elite Quds Force are believed to be instrumental in providing the Houthis with advanced drone and missile technology. Reports indicate that the Houthis have used Iranian-designed Shahed-series drones—similar to those supplied to Russia in the Ukraine conflict—to target shipping lanes and military assets.

The United States, United Kingdom, and Saudi Arabia have intercepted multiple Iranian weapons shipments destined for Yemen, providing further evidence of Tehran's involvement. In February 2023, the U.S. Navy seized a shipment of Iranian-made precision-guided munitions, while in January 2024, the UK Royal Navy confiscated missile components en route to Houthi forces. These interceptions highlight Iran's continued defiance of international sanctions and arms control measures. Additionally, Western and Gulf intelligence sources suspect that Iranian military advisers are present in Yemen, training Houthi forces in drone warfare and missile deployment strategies.

To address Iran's alleged arms shipments, the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) faces challenges in enforcing the existing arms embargo more effectively. Some proposals include expanding naval patrols in the Arabian Sea, increasing sanctions on Iranian entities linked to arms smuggling, and strengthening intelligence-sharing between regional allies.

The Impact of the Conflict on Global Trade and Energy Security

The conflict in Yemen, particularly the recent escalation of Houthi maritime attacks in the Red Sea and Bab el-Mandeb Strait, has had severe consequences for global trade and energy security. The Bab el-Mandeb Strait, a narrow chokepoint linking the Indian Ocean to the Mediterranean via the Suez Canal, is a critical artery for international shipping. Approximately 10% of global trade and 40% of Asia-Europe trade pass through this waterway, including significant shipments of crude oil, liquefied natural gas (LNG), and other essential goods.

The security risks posed by Houthi drone and missile attacks have led major shipping companies, including Maersk, MSC, and Hapag-Lloyd, to suspend operations in the Red Sea, opting for longer and costlier routes around Africa. This diversion has added at least 10-15 days to shipping times between Asia and Europe, increasing fuel costs and delaying deliveries.

The Middle East accounts for about 30% of global crude oil production, with Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Iraq exporting significant quantities through the Red Sea. Any disruption to these shipments has immediate consequences for global oil markets. Following the intensification of Houthi attacks in December 2023 and January 2024, oil prices spiked, with Brent crude surpassing \$80 per barrel due to concerns over supply stability. Energy companies have also been forced to secure alternative shipping routes, further driving up costs. The Houthi threat extends to LNG exports from Qatar, which are crucial for European and Asian energy markets. If attacks continue, energy-importing nations such as India, China, and EU member states may face supply shortages, especially during peak demand seasons.

In response to the maritime threats, the U.S. launched Operation Prosperity Guardian in late 2023, a coalition aimed at protecting shipping lanes in the Red Sea. Countries like the UK and France have deployed warships to escort commercial vessels, while regional powers, including Saudi Arabia and Egypt, have increased their naval surveillance efforts. However, these military responses have led to increased tensions and risks of wider conflict, as seen in the U.S.-UK airstrikes on Houthi military sites in early 2024.

The presence of military convoys and warships in the Red Sea raises concerns about potential clashes, particularly with Iranian-backed Houthi forces, increasing the risk of miscalculations and unintended escalations. Shipping companies must now factor in higher security costs, armed escorts, and rerouting expenses, all of which contribute to rising operational costs that are ultimately passed on to consumers worldwide.

Role of UN Agencies

The United Nations (UN) and its specialized agencies play a crucial role in addressing the humanitarian, security, and political dimensions of the Yemen conflict. The UN Security Council (UNSC) has passed multiple resolutions, including Resolution 2216 (2015), imposing an arms embargo on the Houthis and calling for a peaceful resolution. The United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) coordinates aid efforts, delivering food, medical supplies, and essential services to millions of displaced Yemenis.

The United Nations Mission to Support the Hudaydah Agreement (UNMHA) monitors ceasefire agreements in key ports, aiming to prevent further escalations. The United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) works on rebuilding infrastructure and providing economic support to stabilize the country. Additionally, the UN Panel of Experts on Yemen investigates arms shipments and violations of international law, particularly Iran's alleged supply of weapons to the Houthis.

The International Maritime Organization (IMO) collaborates with member states to enhance maritime security in the Red Sea, ensuring the protection of global trade routes. Despite these efforts, continued conflict and geopolitical tensions challenge the UN's ability to enforce resolutions, making diplomatic negotiations and stronger enforcement mechanisms vital for long-term stability.

The United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs (OCHA) plays a central role in coordinating international humanitarian aid for Yemen, where over 21 million people (roughly 80% of the population) require some form of humanitarian assistance. OCHA collaborates with NGOs and UN agencies to deliver food, medical aid, clean water, and shelter to those affected by the conflict. The World Food Programme (WFP) has been instrumental in providing emergency food aid to prevent famine, while the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF) addresses malnutrition, supports access to clean water, and provides healthcare and education for children impacted by war.

The United Nations Special Envoy for Yemen, currently Hans Grundberg, is responsible for diplomatic mediation efforts between the conflicting parties, including the Houthis, the Yemeni government, and regional actors such as Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Iran. The United Nations Mission to Support the Hudaydah Agreement (UNMHA) was established under UNSC Resolution 2452 (2019) to oversee the implementation of the Stockholm Agreement, which included a ceasefire in Hudaydah, a vital port city for humanitarian aid and commercial imports. However, persistent violations of ceasefires and ongoing clashes have hindered the effectiveness of these diplomatic efforts.

The UN Panel of Experts on Yemen, under the UN Security Council Sanctions Committee, monitors violations of the arms embargo imposed on the Houthis and their allies. Intelligence reports and UN investigations suggest that Iran has been supplying the Houthis with ballistic missiles, drones, and naval mines, which have been used in attacks on commercial and military vessels in the Red Sea. The United Nations Institute for Disarmament Research (UNIDIR) also contributes by tracking the proliferation of arms in Yemen and assessing security risks posed by illicit weapons shipments.

The International Maritime Organization (IMO) has issued warnings about Houthi maritime threats, working closely with regional navies and commercial shipping entities to enhance security protocols and minimize disruptions to global trade through the Red Sea and Bab el-Mandeb Strait. The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) also plays a role in countering the smuggling of arms, fuel, and narcotics, which help fund armed groups in Yemen, including the Houthis.

The UN plays a crucial yet challenging role in addressing the conflict in Yemen, balancing diplomatic mediation, humanitarian aid, security monitoring, and reconstruction efforts. However, the complexity of the conflict, marked by proxy warfare, economic devastation, and maritime security threats, requires stronger international cooperation. Without sustained diplomatic engagement, robust enforcement of sanctions, and enhanced humanitarian support, achieving peace and stability in Yemen will remain a distant goal. The success of UN agencies will depend on greater political will from member states, increased funding, and coordinated regional efforts to de-escalate tensions and prevent further humanitarian catastrophe.

Role of the P5 Nations

The Permanent Five (P5) members of the United Nations Security Council (UNSC)—United States (US), United Kingdom (UK), China, Russia, and France—play a critical role in shaping diplomatic, military, and economic policies concerning Yemen.

1. United States of America:

The US has been a key player in the Yemen conflict, primarily due to its strategic partnership with Saudi Arabia and the UAE, its concerns about Iranian influence in the region, and the protection of global trade routes in the Red Sea.

Since 2015, the US has provided intelligence, logistical support, and arms sales to Saudi Arabia and the UAE in their fight against the Houthis. The US has conducted airstrikes and drone operations targeting Al-Qaeda in the Arabian Peninsula (AQAP) and ISIS-Yemen, which have used the conflict to expand their presence.

Following increased Houthi missile and drone strikes on commercial vessels in the Red Sea in late 2023 and early 2024, the US launched Operation Prosperity Guardian, a multinational coalition aimed at securing maritime trade routes.

The US, along with the UK, has conducted airstrikes on Houthi military targets and imposed sanctions on Iranian individuals and entities accused of supplying weapons to the Houthis. Despite its military involvement, the US has also supported peace negotiations led by the UN Special Envoy for Yemen and engaged in diplomatic talks with Saudi Arabia and Iran to de-escalate tensions.

2. United Kingdom:

The UK plays a dual role in the Yemen conflict—as a major arms supplier to Saudi Arabia and as a diplomatic actor pushing for a political solution.

The UK has provided arms exports, intelligence sharing, and military training to Saudi-led coalition forces. The UK has publicly condemned Houthi drone and missile strikes, particularly those targeting Red Sea shipping.

The UK has participated in Operation Prosperity Guardian and, alongside the US, launched airstrikes against Houthi military sites in response to their maritime attacks.

While militarily involved, the UK has also been a major donor to UN humanitarian operations, providing aid through the Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office (FCDO).

As the penholder for Yemen at the UNSC, the UK has played a key role in drafting resolutions, including Resolution 2216 (2015), which imposed an arms embargo on the Houthis.

3. China

China has largely taken a neutral stance, focusing on diplomatic mediation, economic interests, and non-interference in the internal affairs of Yemen.

China has supported UN-led peace efforts and has called for a political resolution to the conflict while opposing foreign military intervention.

It is heavily invested in global shipping routes, including the Red Sea, which is critical to its Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). The conflict poses risks to Chinese trade interests. China maintains strong relations with Iran, a key supporter of the Houthis, and has avoided directly condemning Iran's alleged arms shipments to the group.

China has deployed warships to protect commercial vessels from Houthi attacks but has refrained from military strikes or direct intervention.

4. Russia

Russia's position on Yemen reflects its broader Middle East strategy, balancing relations with Iran, Saudi Arabia, and the UAE while opposing Western military interventions.

Russia has called for dialogue between all parties and opposed sanctions on the Houthis, arguing that they exacerbate the humanitarian crisis. It has strengthened its strategic alliance with Iran, which has led to speculation that it may indirectly support Iranian arms transfers to the Houthis.

Despite its ties with Iran, Russia has also sought to expand weapons sales to Gulf states, positioning itself as an alternative to Western arms suppliers.

Russia has criticized US and UK airstrikes on Houthi targets, viewing them as an escalation of the conflict and a violation of Yemen's sovereignty. It has increased its naval presence in the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden, citing concerns over regional security and Western military dominance in key maritime routes.

5. France

France has taken a balanced approach, participating in Western-led security initiatives while also emphasizing the need for diplomatic solutions.

France has deployed warships in the Red Sea to protect commercial shipping and has supported Operation Prosperity Guardian. It has strongly condemned Houthi missile strikes on Red Sea trade routes, calling for international action to safeguard maritime security.

France has sold weapons to Saudi Arabia and the UAE, contributing to their military campaigns in Yemen. It has supported UN-led peace negotiations and has urged both Iran and Saudi Arabia to engage in constructive dialogue.

France has provided funding to UN relief programs for Yemen, particularly focusing on medical aid and food security.

United States and Saudi Arabia's Role and Interference in the Yemen Conflict

The United States (US) and Saudi Arabia have played central roles in the Yemen conflict since its escalation in 2015, driven by their strategic interests in countering Iranian influence, securing maritime trade routes, and combating terrorism. While both nations have worked together in military and diplomatic efforts, their involvement has also led to controversies regarding humanitarian crises, arms sales, and geopolitical maneuvering.

The US has supported Saudi Arabia's military campaign against the Iran-backed Houthi rebels, initially providing intelligence, logistics, and billions of dollars in arms sales. Under the Obama administration, the US backed the Saudi-led coalition, believing that a quick military intervention could restore Yemen's internationally recognized government. However, the war escalated into a prolonged humanitarian crisis, with mounting civilian casualties and widespread famine. The Trump administration further strengthened military ties with Riyadh, approving extensive arms deals and intensifying counterterrorism operations targeting Al-Qaeda in Yemen.

In contrast, the Biden administration adopted a more cautious approach, halting support for Saudi-led offensive operations while continuing defensive aid and counterterrorism efforts. Despite these policy shifts, the US remains deeply entangled in the conflict, balancing its strategic interests in countering Iran, securing maritime trade routes, and upholding alliances in the Gulf.

Saudi Arabia, on the other hand, sees the Yemen conflict as a critical front in its regional struggle with Iran. Fearing a hostile Iranian proxy on its southern border, Riyadh launched an aggressive military campaign in 2015, deploying airstrikes and ground forces against the Houthis. The Saudi-led blockade on Yemen, intended to cut off Houthi supply lines, has also contributed to one of the world's worst humanitarian crises, restricting essential food and medical supplies. Despite years of military intervention, Saudi Arabia has been unable to decisively defeat the Houthis, who have retaliated with missile and drone strikes on Saudi cities and oil facilities, including the devastating attack on Aramco in 2019.

Recently, Saudi Arabia has shifted toward diplomacy, engaging in direct talks with the Houthis, brokered by Oman, in an effort to de-escalate tensions. This change in approach reflects war fatigue, rising economic concerns, and a broader regional recalibration following the Saudi-Iran détente.

Human rights organizations and the United Nations have accused the Saudi-led coalition of war crimes, particularly for airstrikes on civilian areas. The US, despite its calls for peace, has been criticized for arming Saudi Arabia while simultaneously positioning itself as a mediator. The failure of military intervention to bring about a decisive victory has led to increasing international pressure for a negotiated settlement.

